Eliminative Materialism

The Churchlands' case that folk psychology is a false theory, and three issues it faces

This workbook consolidates what you have covered in the slideshow and handout. Work through it in order, or jump to the part you need. Every task can be done on your own, so if you missed a lesson you can still catch up. Answers to the recall tasks are at the back: try first, then check.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

In this workbook

1. Where am I now? A self-check
2. Key terms
3. Quick recall
4. Argument reconstruction
5. Objections and evaluation
6. Exam practice (3, 5, 12 and 25 marks)
7. Answers

> **Key Thesis**
> Some or all common-sense (**folk-psychological**) mental states, such as beliefs, desires and qualia, **do not exist**, and our common-sense understanding of the mind is **radically mistaken**. As neuroscience advances, folk psychology will be abandoned, as earlier false theories were (as defended by Patricia and Paul Churchland).

Part 01 Where am I now?

How to use this section

Tick a column for each statement **before** you start, then again **when you finish**. Green = I could explain it to someone else. Amber = I half get it. Red = not yet.

I can...	Start	End
state eliminative materialism and how it differs from reductive physicalism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain folk psychology and its four aspects	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
use historical examples of eliminated theories (caloric, vital force, the aether)	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain Churchland's three failures of folk psychology	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain why intuitions are not a reliable guide (Wittgenstein's sun example)	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the three spec issues: certainty, predictive power, self-refutation	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
reach and defend a judgement on eliminative materialism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G

Part 02 Key terms

Task 1 · Match the term to its definition

Write the letter of the correct definition next to each term.

Term	Letter
Eliminative materialism	
Folk psychology	
Propositional attitude	
Intentionality	
Reductive physicalism	
Elimination	
Self-refuting	

Term	Letter
Predictive power	

	Definition
A	A claim whose assertion undermines itself.
B	The view that some or all folk-psychological mental states do not exist and folk psychology is radically mistaken.
C	Mental states exist and are identical to (reducible to) physical states.
D	The 'aboutness' of mental states: their being directed at something.
E	A mental state directed at a proposition, e.g. believing that, desiring that, hoping that.
F	Our everyday, common-sense theory explaining and predicting behaviour in terms of beliefs, desires and so on.
G	A theory's ability to correctly forecast what will happen.
H	Abandoning the entities of a false theory, rather than reducing them to the entities of a better theory.

Task 2 · Fill the gaps

Use the word bank. Each word is used once.

Key idea Word bank: sleep · believe · vital · desires · psychology · self-refuting · neuroscience · aether

Eliminative materialists claim that folk _____ is a false empirical theory. Just as the _____, caloric fluid and _____ force were abandoned as science progressed, beliefs and _____ will be abandoned once _____ matures. Paul Churchland argues that folk psychology cannot explain mental illness, _____ or intelligence, and has made no real progress in thousands of years. Critics argue the theory is _____: to persuade us, it must change what we _____.

Task 3 · In your own words

Explain why eliminativists think the 'it seems obvious that I have beliefs' response is no better than 'it seems obvious that the sun goes round the earth'.

Part 03 Quick recall

How to use this section

Answer from memory first. Then check your notes, and add anything you missed in a different colour. That second colour shows you exactly what to revise.

1. How does eliminative materialism differ from mind–brain identity theory?

2. Name the four aspects of folk psychology on your slides.

3. Give two examples of theories abandoned by science.

4. State Churchland's three failures of folk psychology.

5. What is the point of Wittgenstein's 'how would it look...?' question?

6. What is the 'certainty' objection?

7. What is the predictive-power objection (Louise Antony)?

8. Why is eliminativism said to be self-refuting?

Part 04 Argument reconstruction

How to use this section

Each argument below has been jumbled. Number the lines into the right order (premises first, conclusion last). Then answer the questions underneath. Being able to set out an argument in standard form is exactly what the 5-mark and 12-mark questions reward.

The Churchlands' argument for elimination

Order	Jumbled line
	The entities posited by a false theory, like caloric fluid, do not exist.
	Therefore, beliefs, desires and other folk-psychological states probably do not exist.
	So folk psychology is probably false.
	Folk psychology is an empirical theory for explaining and predicting behaviour.
	Empirical theories that fail to explain, stagnate and do not fit with our best science are usually false.
	Folk psychology fails to explain mental illness, sleep and intelligence, has stagnated for millennia, and does not fit with neuroscience.

→ Which premise would a critic deny if they think folk psychology is not a *theory* at all?

→ Is 'it has made no progress' fair? Could folk psychology simply be good enough already?

The self-refutation objection

Order	Jumbled line
	To sincerely assert something is to express a belief in it.
	The eliminativist asserts that there are no beliefs.
	So the eliminativist's assertion and argument presuppose that beliefs exist.
	To argue is to try to change what others believe.

Order	Jumbled line
	Therefore, eliminative materialism undermines itself.

→ How might the Churchlands reply that this begs the question (assumes folk-psychological terms to describe assertion)?

→ Why does this objection hit eliminativism about *intentionality* hardest?

Part 05 Objections and evaluation

How to use this section

For each objection: explain the problem in your own words, write the best response, then judge whether the response works. The hint column is there if you are stuck; cover it up if you want a harder challenge.

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Certainty of my own mental states	'I think' — what could be more certain?			
Predictive and explanatory power	We predict each other brilliantly every day.			
Self-refuting	Argument requires belief and intention to persuade.			

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Counter-intuitive	Being told we don't think is not like being told the earth moves.			
Qualia	Isn't seeing blue just obvious?			
Psychology depends on folk psychology	Abandon one, lose the other?			

Ranking the objections

Which objection is the **most** damaging, and which is the **least**? Justify your choice: a strong objection attacks a key premise and is hard to answer.

Most damaging: _____ because...

Least damaging: _____ because...

Building a judgement

Is eliminative materialism self-refuting? Decide whether the theory can state itself without relying on the very concepts it rejects.

Key idea Sentence starters: *The strongest argument for this view is... because...* · *However, this is undermined by...* · *A defender might reply that... but this fails / succeeds because...* · *Therefore, on balance...*

Part 06 Exam practice

How to use this section

On Paper 2 the **3-, 5- and 12-mark** questions test **AO1** only: knowledge and understanding, shown through precise, accurate explanation. The **25-mark** question is **5 marks AO1 + 20 marks AO2**: you must argue, evaluate and reach a judgement that your essay supports throughout.

Spend roughly a minute per mark. Plan before you write.

3 marks · What is meant by 'folk psychology'?

Key idea AO1 · A precise definition or short point. One or two accurate sentences; no evaluation needed.

5 marks · Explain why eliminative materialists believe folk psychology is false.

Key idea AO1 · Set out the idea or argument clearly and in logical order. Precise terminology; a standard-form layout often works best.

Planning frame

1. Define eliminative materialism.
2. Folk psychology is an empirical theory.
3. Its failures (explanation, stagnation, fit with science).
4. Comparison with abandoned theories, so its entities do not exist.

12 marks · Explain how the claim that eliminative materialism is self-refuting challenges the theory, and how an eliminativist might respond.

Key idea AO1 · A full, precise explanation. Show how the ideas connect logically, step by step. Do **not** evaluate: explain.

Planning frame

1. State eliminative materialism precisely.
2. Set out the self-refutation argument in steps.
3. Explain why asserting and arguing seem to need beliefs.
4. Explain the reply: this begs the question by assuming folk-psychological descriptions.

Extra notes

25 marks · Is eliminative materialism true?

Key idea AO1 (5) + AO2 (20) · State your line of argument in the introduction and keep to it. Every paragraph should argue, not just describe: point → objection → response → mini-judgement. End with a conclusion that follows from what you have argued.

Model structure

Section	What to do	My plan
Introduction	Define the key terms. State your thesis: the answer you will defend.	
Paragraph 1	The case: folk psychology's failures and historical elimination → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 2	Certainty about our own mental states → reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 3	Predictive power of folk psychology → reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 4	Self-refutation → reply → mini-judgement.	
Conclusion	Restate your judgement and explain **why** the balance of argument supports it. No new arguments.	

Write your essay on lined paper, or continue below.

Reflect

Go back to Part 01 and fill in the **End** column. Which statement is still red or amber? Write one specific thing you will do about it.

Part 07 Answers

> **How to use this section**
> Use these to check Parts 02–04. Exam answers are not given here: bring them to your teacher, or mark against the AO guidance.

Task 1 · Matching

Eliminative materialism = B · Folk psychology = F · Propositional attitude = E · Intentionality = D · Reductive physicalism = C · Elimination = H · Self-refuting = A · Predictive power = G

Task 2 · Gaps

(1) psychology · (2) aether · (3) vital · (4) desires · (5) neuroscience · (6) sleep · (7) self-refuting · (8) believe

Quick recall

1. Identity theory says mental states exist and are brain states; eliminativism says (some) mental states do not exist at all.
2. Deliberating; conceiving of what we want or believe will happen; actions as a function of how we take the world to be; predicting others' behaviour.
3. E.g. Ptolemaic astronomy; Aristotelian physics; the aether; caloric fluid; vital force.
4. It cannot explain mental illness, perception, sleep, intelligence; it has made no real progress; it does not fit with our best science.
5. It would look exactly the same if the earth went round the sun, so appearances don't settle the matter; likewise for the mind not seeming to be the brain.
6. I am more certain that I have beliefs and experiences than of any theory that says I don't; the Cartesian 'I think'.
7. Folk psychology predicts behaviour extremely well; psychology depends on it; it is the best hypothesis we have.
8. To assert or argue for it, the eliminativist must believe it and want us to believe it, which uses the very states it denies.

Arguments in order

The Churchlands' argument for elimination

1. Folk psychology is an empirical theory for explaining and predicting behaviour.
2. Empirical theories that fail to explain, stagnate and do not fit with our best science are usually false.
3. Folk psychology fails to explain mental illness, sleep and intelligence, has stagnated for millennia, and does not fit with neuroscience.
4. So folk psychology is probably false.
5. The entities posited by a false theory, like caloric fluid, do not exist.
6. Therefore, beliefs, desires and other folk-psychological states probably do not exist.

The self-refutation objection

1. The eliminativist asserts that there are no beliefs.
2. To sincerely assert something is to express a belief in it.
3. To argue is to try to change what others believe.
4. So the eliminativist's assertion and argument presuppose that beliefs exist.
5. Therefore, eliminative materialism undermines itself.

Objections: model responses

Objection	Possible response
Certainty of my own mental states	Introspection is itself theory-laden; past certainties (the sun moving) were wrong too.
Predictive and explanatory power	Usefulness is not truth: Ptolemaic astronomy predicted well too. A better neuroscience could do better.
Self-refuting	This assumes folk-psychological descriptions of what arguing is; a future theory would redescribe it.
Counter-intuitive	Strong intuition is not evidence; the motion of the earth was also once 'unthinkable'.
Qualia	Churchland: neuroscience can predict and even describe unusual colour experiences, so we need no non-physical qualia.
Psychology depends on folk psychology	Psychology could be revised and grounded in neuroscience over time.